

Unit Y313: The Ascendancy of France 1610–1715

This theme focuses on the reasons for the importance of France during the reigns of Louis XIII and Louis XIV, the development, extent and significance of absolute monarchy, the contribution of individual ministers to the ascendancy of France, the extent to which French religion and society was strengthened and steps in the development of French status as an international power. The strands identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme. Foreign policy should be studied only to a level appropriate for an understanding of its impact on the theme of the ascendancy of France during this period.

Thematic Study: The Ascendancy of France 1610–1715	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The development of absolute monarchy and the role of ministers	The theory of absolutism; the extent of authority and rule of Louis XIII and Louis XIV; administration and the development of centralisation; provincial administration: officials, including intendants and governors; Versailles as a symbol of absolutism and the image of the monarch; legal position of the king; finances and taxation; noble privileges; the role of individual ministers including Richelieu, Mazarin, Colbert, Le Tellier (Louvois).
Religious developments	The 'Most Christian King'; kings' and ministers' relations with the French Church and the Papacy; relations with the Jesuits and Catholic Orders; Gallicanism, Louis XIV's quarrels with Innocent XI, the <i>regale</i> ; relations with the Huguenots, the Peace of Alais (1629), the Dragonnades and the Revocation of the Edict of Nantes (1685), its impact on the French society and the economy; the significance of Jansenism and royal reactions to it.
Social developments and opposition	The status and prosperity of the nobility, clergy, merchants and peasants; noble and court unrest, Chalais conspiracy, duelling, Day of Dupes, Bourbon and Cinq Mars plots, Fronde; peasant rebellions e.g. the <i>Va-Nu-Pieds</i> (1639), <i>Croquants</i> (1643), peasant hardships and tax revolts in the 1690s.
France as an international power	The aims of French foreign policy, including borders, prestige, territory; France as an international power 1610–1635; impact of the Thirty Years War on France; Louis XIV's wars against Spain, the United Provinces, England and the Holy Roman Empire and their impact; the treaties of Westphalia, Pyrenees, Utrecht as turning points in the ascendancy of France.

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Depth Studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Richelieu's relations with the French court and nobility	The extent of his authority, relations with Louis XIII, Gaston d'Orléans, Marie de' Medici and Marillac e.g. the Day of Dupes (1630); his statesmanship, his principles e.g. ' <i>raison d'état</i> '; his edicts and methods; his policies towards the nobility and court e.g. the edict banning duelling, Montmorency-Bouteville and Cinq Mars; patronage and clientage.
The Fronde 1648–1653	The causes of the Fronde: Richelieu's system and legacy, a royal minority, xenophobia, Mazarin's policies including financial edicts, intendants, relations with the nobility, parlements, office-holders and religious groups; French defeat at Lens (1648); the nature of the Fronde of parlement, the nobility and religion; the leaders, including Condé and Retz; Mazarin's response; opposition, anarchy and bloodshed; Louis XIV during the Fronde; Mazarin exiled, the Peace of Rueil (1653); the significance of the Fronde for the French state.
Versailles and image-making	The cultural impact including entertainment, drama, music, ballet, paintings, embodiment of the glory of ' <i>le Roi Soleil</i> ', architecture, gardens, furniture, statues, art, artefacts, mirrors, materials; the political significance of Versailles, court, mistresses, control of nobility including rituals, etiquette and hierarchy, economic and financial impact, its role in the development of absolutism; international significance, effects on French international prestige and status, reactions to Versailles.